ENSALADA DE JÍCAMA Y PIÑA CON SAL DE CHILE Y ACHIOTE

Jicama and Pineapple Salad with Chile and Achiote Salt

serves 4 to 6

This juicy salad is exactly what I want to eat on a sweltering day. The combination of salt, achiote, and chile is one you'll see used throughout Southern Mexico and one you could sprinkle over almost any combination of raw vegetables and fruit. For this salad, you ideally want a ripe, sweet pineapple. Look for fruit with some yellowing on the skin and sweet smell at the base. Avoid pineapples that have no aroma or smell sour or fermented.

- 1 dried chile de árbol
- 2 teaspoons coarse sea salt
- 1 teaspoon achiote seeds
- 1 medium ripe pineapple
- ½ medium jicama
- 1 tablespoon agave syrup

Tear the chile(s) into small pieces and place in a mortar, discarding the stem. Include the seeds for a spicier salt or discard them, if you prefer. Add the salt and achiote and use the pestle to pound until you have a cohesive salt mixture.

Use a sharp knife to remove the leafy top and outer skin from the pineapple. Cut the pineapple vertically into quarters and then remove the wedges of central core from each one. Cut the cored pineapple quarters into ½-inch pieces and place in a serving bowl.

Peel the jicama and cut it into the same size of ½-inch pieces, adding them to the bowl.

Drizzle the fruit with the agave syrup, sprinkle with the chile salt, and serve.

THE FRAUGHT HISTORY OF PINEAPPLE ON TURTLE ISLAND

Native to South America, pineapples have been cultivated in Mesoamerica for thousands of years. The Maya people in particular often planted the regal fruit among other crops, including tomatoes, avocados, chiles, sweet potatoes, and jicama.

Colonizers in the Caribbean and later Mexico were immediately enamored of pineapples' curious shape and delicious, sweet flavor. They brought them back to Europe, where they became a fashionable status symbol. Eventually, European land thieves built monoculture plantations in the tropical "New World" to grow pineapples at scale with enslaved labor. In the nineteenth century, the appetite for pineapples led to even more land theft in Hawaii.

I hesitated to include an ingredient with such a dark history for Indigenous peoples, especially considering pineapple is still often grown on a large scale using extractive agricultural methods. But it's also important to share these histories so we can appreciate an ingredient's origins and work toward growing them in better ways in the future.